

could arrange a new marriage for Placidia. The elevation of a Vandal-obligated pretender to the throne, whose support would have come from the followers of Licinia Eudoxia, could have truly presented Gaiseric in the West as well as in the East as an "advocate of the empire" and furthermore as a future of great benefit. When Alaric's adopted son captured Rome forty-five years earlier, they recalled with Priscus Attalus a unique? Augustus.⁵¹ Theodoric already wanted to take a similar step with Aetius in 456.⁵² However, while Aetius and Avitus lacked effective backing in Italy, Gaiseric had the chance to legitimize his candidate through a connection with the dynasty that had ruled for decades. The plundering of Rome and the capture of the empress with her daughters instead make it clear that the Vandal king at this point did not pursue the grand and long-term plans attributed to Wirth. According to Priscus, the assassination of Valentinian III and the subsequent unrest in Rome primarily provided an immediate opportunity for Gaiseric to strengthen his own position.⁵³ The king was certainly well informed about the events, even without direct contact with Licinia Eudoxia or her entourage, and knew that in view of the division in the Roman army, no serious military resistance was to be feared.⁵⁴ This was all the more true for the kind of swift operations that the Vandals had already carried out successfully multiple times.⁵⁵ The fact that the treaty of 442 had been suspended by Valentinian's death and probably not reconfirmed by Petronius Maximus could also be interpreted as a hostile act and thus justify the Vandal intentions.⁵⁶ After Gaiseric had taken Rome as planned, he removed everything from the city that could be considered valuable in any way. This naturally included both minted and unminted precious metals, as well as prominent captives. The empress, her two daughters, Aetius' son Gaudentius, and several senators were for Gaiseric not only potential sources of ransom but primarily an invaluable political pawn. Even without further extensive plans

51. Regarding Alaric, cf. Demandt, 1989, p. 144 f., regarding Avitus below VIII.1.2.

52. Prisc. frg. 30,1 J. Antioch. frg. 201,6: Καὶ Γίζιριχος τῶν Βανδάλων ἄρχων τῶν ἑτοῦ καὶ Βαλεντινιανοῦ Εὐδοχίαν ποικιδόντι πειθεσθαι ταῖς Ἰταλίαις καὶ τὴν ἡγεσμένον, ὅς τινι μὲν ἐργῆς θανόντι τὴν βασιλευντων λυσάμενης, τοῦ δὲ ἐκ τῶν βασιλευσάντων παρελθόντος μὲν ξιοχρῶν κεκτημένου δυνάμει. (And Gaiseric, the ruler of the Vandals, considering the time ripe for attacking Italy, taking advantage of Aetius and Valentinian Eudoxia, as the peace was broken by the death of the rulers, and he himself did not possess sufficient power to ascend to the throne.)

53. According to Priscus, the army was divided over Valentinian's succession (s.o.). – O'Flynn, 1983, p. 160 note 12, suggests a collaboration between Gaiseric and Licinia Eudoxia, "...the imperial ladies could have escaped from Rome prior to Gaiseric's arrival had they seriously wished to do so." A voluntary stay in Rome could indeed provide clues about Licinia Eudoxia's own view of things, but not necessarily about Gaiseric's intentions. Whether there were points of contact here is uncertain.

54. As during their crossing to Africa in 429 or the capture of Carthage ten years later. Similar actions also led to successes against Majorian in 460 and against the East Roman fleet in 468. Cf. below VII.3.2.

55. Cf. Prisc. frg. 30,1 (s.o. note 52), Seeck, 1920, p. 324; Schmidt, 1942, p. 77 f.

56. PLRE II s.v. Gaudentius 7. Anicius Olybrius, however, the fiancé of Placidia, escaped a similar fate because he was in Constantinople in 455. Max, 1975, p. 63; Clover, 1978, pp. 176–179.

plans to pursue with them, this consideration alone might have motivated the Vandal attack. However, it is methodologically uncertain whether Gaiseric in 455 saw himself as a protector of the Theodosian house and an advocate of legitimist ideas.⁵⁷ The result of the approximately nine months between September 454 and June 455 was a disaster for the Roman side: two emperors had been murdered, the dynasty that had ruled for over sixty years had been overthrown and the throne was vacant, the city plundered, the provinces restless, the previous consensus within the senatorial aristocracy irrevocably terminated. The crisis of 454/5 had created problems that would burden the Western Roman Empire for decades.⁵⁸

57. That Gaiseric primarily wanted to make loot, as Proc. BV I 5,1 claims, is rejected by Clover, 1966, p. 145 f., and explained as a reflection of the impression the author of the treasures of 455 left on Procopius eighty years later. In contrast, Courtois, 1955, p. 196, with Gautier, 1937, p. 38, sees the conquest of Rome as "une magnifique entreprise de piraterie sur une très grande échelle, une affaire exceptionnellement fructueuse". This apparently corresponds to reality.

58. Eastern authors later saw the murder of Aetius as the beginning of the end: Marc. Com. s.a. 454,2 = Chron. Min. II, p. 86: cum ipso (sc. Aetio) Hesperium cecidit regnum nec hactenus valuit relevari (then Paul. Diac. hist. Rom. XIV 15). Similarly Proc. BV 14,28: Prisc. frg. 30,1 = J. Antioch. frg. 201,2 f. Marcellinus probably only reflects a tradition within Anician historiography (so Momigliano, 1956, p. 235 f.; Wes, 1967, pp. 110–116 a. 170–173; Zecchini, 1981, p. 124). Priscus and Procopius, who followed him, however, show that Aetius' death was also viewed outside the Anicians as an overall Roman loss.